Institute of Archaeology

Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya Campus

Ministry of Culture

Prospectus 2027 – Post-Graduate Diploma in Archaeology (PGDA)

Overview

The idea of a specialized institution for the advancement of archaeological studies in the country was conceived in 1944. This marked the beginning of efforts to formalize archaeological education and research under the auspices of the Archaeological Survey of India. This took the form of excavation training camps being organised to train the youth in the science of excavations and coping up with the rigours of field life. In 1959, equipped with the vision to have a structured programme for training archaeologists in all spheres of the subject, the School of Archaeology was formally established under the Archaeological Survey of India. This institution was intended to mark a significant step in institutionalizing archaeological studies in India. Initially, the focus was on foundational training, fieldwork and the study of Indian history through material culture. The School offered a one-year Post-graduate Diploma in Archaeology course.

Recognizing the growing importance and scope of archaeological research, the School of Archaeology was upgraded to the Institute of Archaeology in 1985. This was also in conformity with the R.N. Mirdha report of 1983 that had stressed on archaeological research in addition to teaching and training of students for a career in archaeology. The new status allowed the Institute to offer advanced programmes in archaeology and heritage management and engage in more extensive research projects. The Post-Graduate Diploma in Archaeology being offered by the erstwhile School of Archaeology now became a two-year programme with extensive educational and training schedules.

The School of Archaeology, since its inception, functioned from 11 Janpath. After it was upgraded to the Institute of Archaeology it began functioning from the stately white building of Lutyen's Delhi at 24 Tilak Marg. In October 2005, the Institute of Archaeology shifted to one of the colonial buildings within the Red Fort complex in Old Delhi. Subsequently, in 2019 the Institute of Archaeology shifted to Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya campus, Knowledge Park II, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh.

The new 25 acre campus was inaugurated by the Hon'ble Prime Minister. In 2024, the course was further redesigned and modified to realign with the need for more hands-on training. The current course structure is again back to one year duration and the academic session now conforms with the calendar year beginning in the month of January.

Academic Programme

The Institute of Archaeology offers a one-year course in Post-Graduate Diploma in Archaeology. The medium of instruction is in English and Hindi both. The academic session shall commence from January onwards.

Faculty

The Institute invites domain experts from the Archaeological Survey of India and academicians from universities, colleges and other educational institutes to deliver lectures for our students.

Facilities and Resources

Library

The library of the Institute is located in the B-wing on the ground floor of the academic-cum-administrative block. There are more than 20,000 books. Additionally, dissertations submitted by students of PGDA are also kept as per academic sessions and are available for consultation by the students. It is planned to have a digital library at its campus.

Labs

The Institute has a dedicated computer lab which is available for the use of students as per requirement. All the equipment's are connected with Wi-Fi. In addition, a Science lab is present on the second floor of the building. Preservation and conservation of different artefacts are conducted here and students are imparted training here. The lab also has good number of high-end machines to cater to scientific analysis of various category of artefacts – both organic and inorganic.

Community Centre

The community centre housed in a two-story separate building has a multi-purpose hall in the ground floor. The first floor of the building houses a gymnasium equipped with different machines for the use of all students and officials.

Additionally, kits for outdoor and indoor games like cricket, volleyball, badminton, table-tennis, carrom, chess, etc., are also available for the use of students.

Qualifications

Educational qualification for admission is Master's Degree in Ancient Indian History/ Culture / Archaeology. Minimum qualifying marks is 55% in aggregate, relaxable by 5% in case of SC/ST and OBC candidates and in-service candidates from Centre/State governments and Universities and Colleges.

Number of Seats

Admission to the PGDA course is conducted for 15 seats every year.

In case of in-service candidates (serving archaeologists) from state governments, museums, universities, colleges, etc., application should be forwarded through proper channel to the Administrator (IoA).

Reservation

Reservation for SC/ ST/ OBC/ EWS, etc. is provided as per the Government of India regulations issued time to time.

Age Limit

The maximum age limit for fresh candidates is 25 years. The upper age limit is relaxable by 5 years for SC/ ST candidates, 3 years for OBC (Non-Creamy layer) candidates.

There is no age bar for in-service candidates from the Archaeological Survey of India, or candidates sponsored by state departments of archaeology/ museums/universities or colleges teaching the subject of archaeology.

Candidates from SAARC and BIMSTEC nations will be governed by guidelines from Ministry of External Affairs, Govt. of India and Indian Council of Cultural Relation (ICCR).

Admission

For entry of every new batch of students in PGDA course, the process of entrance is initiated in the month of October.

An indicative advertisement is published in the Employment News, with details given on the website of the Institute of Archaeology. The same is reflected on the website of the Archaeological Survey of India as well. For wider publicity the link is shared on social media platforms.

The last date for receiving of applications is 15 days from the activation of the link on the website i.e. till 11:59PM on 31/10/2026. In case any technical issues arise during this period, the last date of application shall be increased proportionately.

Mode of application will be exclusively online only.

In-service candidates are required to submit their application through proper channel to the Administrator, IoA.

Selection

Selection process for the PGDA course comprises of a written test (Hindi or English) followed by a personal interview of shortlisted candidates. This will be undertaken in the month of November.

The marks for the entire process shall be out of 100 – ratio of marks between written and personal interview shall be 70:30.

The written test will be a combination of multiple-choice objective type questions, short notes, and one essay type question on ancient history and archaeology.

Time

The question paper shall be attempted within the duration of 2 hours.

Personal Interview

Applicants will be shortlisted on the basis of their performance in the written test for personal interview. The list of the shortlisted candidates shall be made public for information of all through website and notice board.

Personal interview of the shortlisted candidates from written examination shall be carried out on the day after declaration of result for written test.

The final declaration of result will be in the month of December.

Stipend

The Institute provides 15 stipends of Rs.8,000/- per month to the fresh students joining the course. Besides this, the Institute also bears travel cost of students during tours to different parts of the country.

The stipend is **under review for an increase**, pending approval by the competent authority.

Accommodation

Students are provided with hostel facility within the sprawling Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya campus in Knowledge Park II, Greater Noida on twin sharing basis. The rooms are equipped with attached washroom and a small veranda. Kitchen and dining room are available for hostellers. Provision for food is made by the Institute, but fixed contribution of Rs 2100/- per month has to be made by students. This amount may undergo revision in case there is any change in the monthly stipend to be paid. During the field session students shall run their own mess. Security guards are present 24x7 in the hostel. Room charge of Rs 250/- per month is debited from the student's stipend, which may also undergo revision in case there is any change in the monthly stipend to be paid.

Attendance

Student must have minimum 85% attendance inclusive of training camps and study tours. Students falling short of required attendance will not be eligible for award of Diploma.

No leave is permissible to students during the academic session. Leave is admissible only under unforeseeable exigent circumstances for which prior permission of the Director of the Institute or his/her representative is required.

Attendance below 85% shall result in rustication of the student from the course.

Declaration

At the time of the admission to the PGDA course, the student will have to sign and submit a surety bond. Among other things, through the bond the students shall declare and submit to the following:

1. Whether pursuing any additional educational course through distance or otherwise – Masters degree; M.Phil, Ph.D., etc.
2. Whether they have been awarded and are recipient of any fellowship / scholarship, etc.
3. Intimation of application to other academic courses or jobs.
4. In case a student shall leave the course mid-session due to any reason, he/she will have to reimburse stipend received till then and other financial liabilities that were borne by the Institute like train tickets, paid accommodation on tours, etc.

Academic Calendar

The academic session shall commence from the 1st January with an orientation programme. Total duration of the course will be one year. This will include theoretical lessons, a two month long Excavation and Exploration training camp, other field work, and completion and submission of Dissertation by students.

Syllabus

This is an indicative list only.

Students shall have 11 subject papers including 8 theoretical papers, one practical training in excavation, one dissertation and one viva-voce.

Paper 1: Archaeology: History, Field Methods & Theory

Unit 1

- Introduction to Archaeology – definitions, scope, terminology
- Development of Archaeology – from antiquarianism to scientific discipline
- History of the Archaeological Survey India; Indian archaeologists
- Archaeology and other disciplines
- Theoretical foundations in Archaeology – Processual; Post-processual; New archaeology, etc.

Unit 2

- Site formation processes
- Exploration – Field survey methods – traditional and scientific
- Case studies – Prehistory and Protohistory; Historical; Medieval
- Excavation techniques
- Underwater archaeology

Unit 3

- Natural sciences and Archaeology (Anthropology; Paleobotany; Paleozoology; Osteology)
- Earth science sand Archaeology (Palaeo - environment reconstruction; Geology; Geomorphology)
- Quantitative methods and Information science.
- Archaeological Chemistry.

- Archaeo-Metallurgy

Unit 4

- Retrieval, sampling and analysis of botanical, zoological and other non-artifactual remains
- Relative dating
- Absolute dating

Unit 5

- Recording, Documentation, Reconstruction
- Drawing – section, elevation, plan; pottery, stone tool, burial, antiquity, etc.
- Imaging
- Field laboratory
- Chapterization; preparation of text; dummy and proof reading

Paper 2: Human Societies

Unit 1

- Human evolution and hominid fossils – India and World
- Palaeolithic cultures – India and World
- Mesolithic culture – India and World
- Rock Art – India and World

Unit 2

- Neolithic culture
- Chalcolithic cultures of India – Rajasthan, North and Central India
- Chalcolithic cultures of Ganga plain, north-east region and Odisha
- Deccan Chalcolithic
- Neo-Chalcolithic cultures of South India

Unit 3

- Harappan studies
- Early Harappan
- Mature Harappan – transition from early to mature
- Urbanization

Unit 4

- Late Harappan – transition from mature to late
- Decline of Harappan Civilisation – theories
- Harappan legacy – OCP; Copper Hoards

Unit 5

- Iron technology and debates
- Iron age cultures of Ganga plain
- Megalithic cultures of Deccan
- Megalithic cultures of South India

Paper 3: Historical Archaeology

Unit 1

- Historical geography

- Archaeology and Text: Indigenous and Extraneous
- Epics and archaeological tradition
- Sources: Epigraphic; Numismatics
- Urbanization

Unit 2

- Defining 'Early historical' – Theories and Debates (6th century BCE – beginning of Common Era)
- Nature and survey of sites
- Material culture
- Trade networks – overland and seas special reference to Indo-Roman trade

Unit 3

- Historical Archaeology (beginning of the Common Era – 5th century CE)
- Nature and survey of sites
- Material culture

Unit 4

- Early Medieval Archaeology (6th century – 12th century CE)
- Defining 'early Medieval' – Theories and Debates
- Nature and survey of sites
- Buddhist monastic establishments
- Trade networks – overland and seas

Unit 5

- Archaeology of the Medieval (13th century – 17th century CE) and Colonial period (18th century – 19th century CE)
- Major medieval and colonial cities/ settlements

Paper 4: Laws and Conventions

Unit 1: Historiography

- History of antiquarian laws in India
- Indian Treasure Trove Act, 1878
- Ancient Monument Preservation Act, 1904
- Antiquities (Export Control) Act, 1947
- Constitution of India
- State legislation

Unit 2: National legislations – movable cultural property

- Antiquarian and Art Treasure Act, 1972 and Rules 1973
- Policies, Guidelines, Standard Operating Procedure (SoP) and Recommendations
- Case studies

Unit 3: National legislations – immovable cultural property

- Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958 and Rules 1959
- Policies, Guidelines, Standard Operating Procedure (SoP) and Recommendations
- Case studies
- National Monument Authority (NMA) – Heritage Bye-laws; Case studies

Unit 4: International Conventions on Movable Cultural property

- The Hague Convention
- Convention on the Means of Prohibiting and Preventing the Illicit Import, Export and Transfer of Ownership of Cultural Property, 1970
- Recommendation for the Protection of Movable Cultural Property, 1978
- Convention on Stolen or Illegally Exported Cultural Objects, 1995
- Retrieval of Antiquities – procedure and case studies
- Policies, Guidelines, SoP and Recommendations

Unit 5: International Conventions on Immovable Cultural property

- Recommendation on International Principles Applicable to Archaeological Excavations, 1956
- International Charter for the Conservation and Restoration of Monuments and Sites, 1964
- Convention concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage, 1972
- The Burra Charter, 1979
- The Florence Charter on Historical Gardens, 1981
- Charter for the Protection and Management of the Archaeological Heritage, 1990
- Nara Document on Authenticity, 1994
- Principles for the Recording of Monuments, Groups of Buildings and Sites, 1996
- Charter on Built Vernacular Heritage, 1999
- Convention on the Protection of Underwater Cultural Heritage, 2001

Paper 5: Training in Exploration and Excavation

- Prehistory – Geology; Rocks and stones; Tool knapping; Tool drawing; Report.
- Exploration – Pre-exploration works, Map reading, using of cutting edges technologies and documentation.
- Excavation – surveying; site plan, layout of trenches, site notebook; 2D and 3D-recording of artefacts, pottery yard, documentation of artefacts; Drawing – section, plan, pottery, burial, antiquity, etc.; Photography

Paper 6: Art, Iconography and Architecture

(Unit 1: Art; Unit 2: Iconography; Unit 3, 4 & 5: Architecture)

Unit 1

- Art in Prehistoric India
- Terracotta – Protohistoric/Harappan; Historic period
- Sculptural Art and Schools
- Metal
- Paintings – Mural and Miniature

Unit 2

- Sources – Texts; Terminology
- Brahmanical
- Buddhist
- Jaina
- Documentation

Unit 3

- Development of stupa architecture

- Rock-cut architecture
- Chaitya and Viharas
- Monasteries

Unit 4

- Texts
- Evolution of temple architecture
- Nagara style
- Dravida style
- Vesara style
- Documentation

Unit 5

- Elements of Indo-Islamic architecture
- Delhi Sultanate; Mughal; Provincial styles
- Mosques, Tombs
- Forts, Palaces, Gardens
- Elements of Colonial Architecture

Paper 7: Epigraphy and Numismatics

(Unit 1 & 2: Epigraphy; Unit 3, 4 & 5: Numismatics)

Unit 1

- Antiquity of writing in India
- Harappan script
- Indic scripts – origin, evolution, decipherment, distribution.
- Arabic-Persian inscriptions – script, eras, chronograms, numerals
- Language; Eras; Dates; Numerals; Symbols; Signs

Unit 2

- Inscriptions as a source material
- Ashoka Rock and Pillar edicts
- Select inscriptions – North and South (Prashasti; Administrative; Copper plate grants)
- Sites through epigraphic records – Barabara-Nagarjuni caves; Sanchi; Kanaganahalli; Nalanda
- Documentation of epigraphic records; Transliteraion; Translation.

Unit 3

- Coins as a source material
- Origin and antiquity of monetary system in India
- Provenance – Coin hoards; excavations
- Technique of minting coins
- Documentation and Cataloguing; Monograms and Symbols

Unit 4

- Punch marked coins
- Cast copper coins
- Foreign coins- Indo-Greek; Sakas
- Satavahana

- Kushana
- Gupta

Unit 5

- Huna; Indo-Sassanian
- Chola; Rajput; Vijaynagara
- Delhi Sultanate; Mughal
- Kashmir; Ahoms

Paper 8: Conservation and Heritage Management

Unit 1

- Terminology
- History of archaeological conservation
- Guiding principles and policies; Marshall's Conservation Manual (1923); National Conservation Policy (2014)

Unit 2

- Causes of Deterioration – Natural and man-made
- Inspection notes; Estimation
- Methodology
- Scientific and Technological innovations and analysis

Unit 3

- Organic – Deterioration; Remedial measures
- Inorganic – Deterioration; Remedial measures
- Mural paintings – Deterioration; Remedial measures

Unit 4

- UNESCO and World Heritage – Outstanding Universal Value and its Framework
- World Heritage Cultural and Natural properties in India
- International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS)
- International Centre for the Study of the Preservation and Restoration of Cultural Property (ICCROM)
- Preparation of WH dossiers – case studies

Unit 5

- Site management plan
- Visitor management
- Disaster management
- Capacity-building
- NMMA

Paper 9: Museology

Unit 1

- Museums; Museology; Museography
- Role of Museums
- Emerging concepts in Museums and Museology

Unit 2

- Museum movement in India
- Types and classification of Museums
- Case studies – Indian Museum, Kolkata; National Museum, Delhi; Salarjung Museum, Hyderabad; Bihar Museum, Patna; Pradhan Mantri Museum, Delhi; Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Manav Sangrahalaya, Bhopal
- ASI museums

Unit 3

- Collection
- Documentation
- Museum marketing
- Security

Unit 4

- Exhibition
- Education
- Research
- Outreach

Unit 5

- Preventive Conservation
- Deterioration and Conservation
- Disaster Preparedness
- ICOM, ICCROM, UNESCO-ICOM Museum Information Centre, IUCN, ICOMOS, MAI
- ICOM Code of Ethics

Paper 10: Dissertation

The students shall submit a dissertation of 18000-20000 words at the end of the academic session. They can choose their topic and supervisor. They shall have to submit a synopsis of the same and give a presentation. The chosen topic shall be approved by the Director, Institute after the presentation. Time period of 27 days shall be given distributed in three phases:

- 9 days in April/May 2027
- 11 days in August, 2027
- 07 days in December, 2027

Paper 11: Viva voce

100 marks shall be distribute as 30 marks, 30 marks and 40 marks for Viva voce to be conducted during the First, Second and Third Trimester examination respectively.

Award of Post-Graduate Diploma in Archaeology

To qualify for Diploma, a student is required to obtain minimum 40% marks in each subject with an aggregate of 50%. Students obtaining 75% marks and above will be awarded Post-Graduate Diploma in Archaeology with Credit.

The student who secures the highest mark in the academic year shall be awarded Gurudev Ranade award constituted in memory of Prof. B.B. Lal.

Each paper will be of adjudicated out of 100 marks. Evaluation of theory papers shall be based upon academic year end examinations as well as internal assessments through tests, assignments, presentations, etc., that will be carried out throughout the course of the year.

The dissertation shall be evaluated on the basis of both the written material as well as a presentation.

Alumni

The Institute of Archaeology with its long and rich legacy has an equally distinguished list of alumni who have excelled in the field of archaeology and by their stellar contribution have brought laurels not only to the Archaeological Survey of India but also their alma mater – Institute of Archaeology. Many erstwhile students from the Institute have made a name for themselves in the field of academics in the service of the discipline – both in India and abroad.

Contact Information

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Location

The Institute of Archaeology is located within the sprawling Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya campus in Knowledge Park II, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh. Greater Noida is an upcoming planned city in District Gautam Buddha Nagar. It is a hub of educational institutions catering to largely a young populace coming from different parts of the country.